

INDIA'S RESPONSE OVERLY CAUTIOUS

Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao may have given a good conduct certificate to India on its response to the Tibet crisis, but the muted Indian reaction to the Chinese crackdown in Lhasa has some foreign policy experts lashing out at what they call New Delhi's "poor handling" of bilateral relations with China. One of them, A.P. Venkateshwaran, a former foreign secretary, says: "The Government has no spine. We kowtow to the Chinese and they think we are irrelevant." Over the years, he argues, India's support for the Tibet cause has been diluted, despite the fact that China has continued to prick India in its strategic neighbourhood.

During the current crisis, the messages from South Block to the Dalai Lama and his senior-most advisers were to not exacerbate the tensions and, sources say, even the Tibetan spiritual leader's statement that he would step down if the violence did not end in Tibet was facilitated by New Delhi. There are political and diplomatic reasons be-

CLAMPING DOWN: Police drag away a Tibetan protester from outside Chinese Embassy in Delhi

hind the Government's overly cautious response. For India to take a more strident stand could see China accuse it of interfering in its internal affairs and Beijing may then change its current hands-off approach on the Kashmir issue.

Also, the Government, in a bid to calm the Left constituents over the Indo-US nuclear deal, has followed their line of maintaining neutrality on the Tibetan issue and not antagonising China over it.

Under the NDA regime in 2002, India explicitly compromised on the

issue of Tibet when the then government signed a memorandum of understanding with China recognising the Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR) as part of the territory of China. Since then, China has continued its policy of systematically relocating Han Chinese into TAR and cracking down on the Tibetan culture. The present crisis is seen as another manifestation of the same policy. Experts say that restraint on India's part has been mistaken for weakness. Last year, there were over 130 intrusions by the Chinese Army into India, including Sikkim, which Beijing recognises as Indian territory. They feel that the crisis presents an important opportunity for India to revive its Tibet card and not undermine it.

by Saurabh Shukla

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days as the great Chinese firewall went into an overdrive.

But, for the first time in memory, the Government beamed pictures of civil unrest on state television and allowed some media discussion of the "Tibet problem". At Wen's annual press conference last week—also broadcast live on state television—foreign reporters were repeatedly called upon to ask questions, allowing the unrest in Tibet to take centre stage. This modicum of openness may be a necessary concession in a society that, while still highly controlled, has greater access to information than ever before. The Government can no longer sweep all trouble in distant provinces under the carpet.

But it was also a planned response

from a government with a growing capacity for media spin. By showing images of Tibetans beating up ethnic Chinese and setting Chinese businesses ablaze to ordinary citizens, Beijing has shored up support for its tough stance on Tibet among the masses. By accepting questions on Tibet from foreign media, the Government can claim to be confronting the issue with a measure of transparency and political maturity.

This is, of course, sheer posturing: Beijing has not made, and is unlikely to make, any concessions either to genuine media freedom or to legitimate demands for greater cultural autonomy in Tibet. As for the protesters, the instigators will be rounded up, possibly tortured and sent off to labour

camps in the time-honoured manner. The Government claims it has regained control in Tibet and that life has basically returned to normal—and that is, for the most part, probably true. Tibetan protests may flare from time to time, but Beijing has no difficulty dousing the flames.

Last week's riots were born of the cultural oppression endured by outsiders in China's supposedly multinational, inclusive state. Like previous protests in Tibet and Xinjiang, the largely Muslim-populated region in China's northwest, this protest will barely dent Beijing's iron grip. Far from winning greater freedom, Tibetans will face greater vigilance as Beijing steps up controls on its most troublesome region. ■